except to dissociate from it, tell your mind that *you* were not *it*. Sunder yourself from yourself. The color sergeants said this was part of their Grand Plan. Kill the Self.

Then we'd all be on the same page. Then we'd truly be One Unit.

As the primacy of Self fades, they promised, the idea of Service takes over.

Platoon, country, that'll be all you know, cadets. And that'll bloody well be enough.

I couldn't tell how the other cadets felt about all this, but I bought in, all the way. Self? I was more than ready to shed that dead weight. Identity? Take it.

I could understand, for someone attached to their self, their identity, that this experience might be harsh. Not me. I rejoiced as slowly, steadily, I felt myself being reduced to an essence, the impurities removed, only the vital stuff remaining.

A little like what happened in Tooloombilla. Only more so.

It all felt like an enormous gift, from the color sergeants, from the Commonwealth.

I loved them for it. At night, before blacking out, I gave thanks.

55.

AFTER THOSE FIRST FIVE weeks, after the close of boot camp, the color sergeants eased up. Ever so slightly. They didn't shout at us quite so much. They treated us like soldiers.

As such, however, it was time to learn about war. How to make it, how to win it. Some of this involved stupefyingly boring classroom lessons. The better bits involved drills simulating different ways of being killed, or not, depending.

CBRN, they were called. Chemical, biological, radiological, nuclear. We practiced putting on protective gear, pulling it off, cleaning and wiping the poisons and other muck that might be thrown, dropped or sprayed on us. We dug countless trenches, donned masks, curled into the fetal position, rehearsed the Book of Revelation over and over.

One day the color sergeants assembled us outside a redbrick building, which had been turned into a CS gas chamber. They ordered us inside, activated the gas.